there remained anxiety that not all launch sites had been photographed; indeed, not all the R-12 *missiles* were photographed. In hindsight, it is evident that by the climax of the crisis, US intelligence had located all the MRBM *launchers* (even if they could not be completely certain they had).

From the outset, the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs was insistent that a first strike would not destroy all the missiles. Continuous air attacks would be necessary (as indeed was planned). Maxwell Taylor had led the 101st Airborne Division into Normandy in June 1944, and therefore spoke with some authority on the role (and limits) of air power. In the meeting with the commander of the Tactical Air Force, General Walter Sweeney, on 21 October, the President was told that it was possible to guarantee that only ninety per cent of *known* missiles could be destroyed.

## Launch on warning

US photo-reconnaissance missions detected thirty-three R-12s. However, all twenty-four MRBM launch sites were eventually identified. The USAF estimated that the first wave of attacking aircraft would give the defenders only ten minutes warning, and the second wave, forty minutes. The warheads for the MRBMs were kept at the main storage depot at Bejucal, some fifty miles from the nearest R-12 regiment.[60] In 2008 Michael Dobbs recounted that General Pliyev decided to move MRBM warheads to one of the missile sites at Sagua la Grande, some 160 miles east of Havana (eight of which arrived on the afternoon of 27 October).[61] His source was several Soviet servicemen involved in the action. The account challenges the view of General Gribkov and others who maintain that no nuclear warheads were dispersed.[62] By 27 October all twenty-four R-12 launchers were ‘operational’. None of the missiles had been fitted with nuclear warheads. This situation was very different with the Jupiter and Thors IRBMs on NATO territory. On 27 October fifty-nine of the sixty Thors could be fired within thirteen or fourteen minutes of a launch order.

James Blight and David Welch explain that: